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Journal of World History, Volume 28, Number 1, March 2017, pp. 107-120 (Article)

Published by University of Hawai'i Press
DOI: *https://doi.org/10.1353/jwh.2017.0004*

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Cotton and the Global Origins of Capitalism*

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GLOBAL history is one of the most vibrant fields within the discipline of history today, an immensely creative flourishing of the historian's craft that has produced a wide variety of studies of great insight and power. These works embrace an eclectic diversity of approaches, questions, and empirical foci, testifying to the expansiveness of the discipline of history. One particular way of doing global history has been to write the history of a commodity, with books focusing on such things as sugar, oil, the potato, and cod. Such commodity-focused histories are one powerful way to move toward a history beyond the nation-state, partly because they give empirical specificity to far-flung connections, partly because they allow us to bring the lessons of social history into global history, partly because they provide audiences for global history, and partly because, if done right, they can help us better understand some of the largest questions of world history. As others have appreciated before me, a commodity-focused history is a perspective that entails lots of analytical possibilities.

Most basically, writing a history of a commodity gives historians an empirical focus for their effort to understand aspects of global or world history. The commodity links distant places, for one thing. If we think of the commodity that I know best—cotton—we can observe, for example, that the global cotton industry connected technologies from China

*Keynote address at the World History Association Annual Conference, held in July 2016 in Ghent, Belgium. Some of the text has been published in Sven Beckert, "The New History of Capitalism," in *Capitalism: The Reemergence of a Historical Concept*, ed. Jürgen Kocka and Marcel van der Linden, (London: Bloomsbury, 2016) 235–50.

Journal of World History, Vol. 28, No. 1
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and India to labor from Africa, capital from Europe to expropriated lands in the Americas, and consumers from Brazil to manufacturers in Great Britain. Studying a commodity forces us to look beyond national boundaries and gives us something to hold onto when drawing out these spatially extensive connections.

Not only do commodity studies emphasize the connections among different parts of the world, they also provide ample opportunity to use the changing forms of global connections to understand local, regional, and national histories. Connections shift frequently; within the history of particular commodities, positions of producers and consumers can shift as well. India, for example, for many centuries the world's largest producer of cotton textiles for transoceanic markets, was replaced in the nineteenth century by Great Britain and even became the world's most significant consumer of British manufactured cottons. Commodity studies are singularly able to trace these changing forms of global connections, since the investigation of networks beyond local or national contexts are at their very core.

As a result, the story that emerges from focusing an investigation on a particular commodity allows us to see the connections between events and developments in distant areas of the world. What seems like a world of endless particularities and conflicting developments becomes more comprehensible as we uncover the unity in the diverse: how very different and distant developments are linked (such as the expansion of slavery and free labor) and how a global system that confronted entrenched local traditions and distributions of power led to different outcomes—colonial control in India, slave labor in the United States, or debt peonage in Egypt, for example.

Moreover, commodity-centered studies provide a fresh understanding of an important subject, the history of capitalism, one of the core themes of modern history. They show that the global reach of capital is not incidental to the history of capitalism, but its essence. Capitalism, from the outset, was global in a way that no other system of organizing economic activities had been. Commodity studies depart dramatically from the vast majority of economic histories that use the nation-state as their frame to discuss such issues as the "British Industrial Revolution," the "American managerial revolution" or the "sprouts of capitalism" in China. Not only do commodity studies break with this nationally bounded focus by following one commodity around the globe—in the process making a powerful argument for the importance of these global connections to the history of capitalism—they also give us a more multifaceted view of capitalism itself, foregrounding the radically new spatial dimensions of economic organization. And in

the process, they allow us to see the history of capitalism in a much less Eurocentric way.

Some of the connections that commodity studies emphasize are those among agriculture, industry, finance, trade, and consumption. A cotton-centered study investigates the ways cotton was grown in fields in Asia, Africa, and the Americas and how it was then spun into thread and woven into cloth in factories on all continents. It analyzes how European capital flowed into the cotton fields and how merchants built marketing networks extending to all corners of the globe. In some ways, uncovering these connections is at the very heart of what a commodity-focused approach is all about.

Particularly important—and as a corrective to some of the more enthusiastic approaches to global history—commodity histories encourage us to bring the state, politics, and power back into explanations of the shifting shape of global connections. Commodity studies show that just as states were central to structuring the emerging global world of capitalism, so, too, the blossoming of so-called free markets was tightly linked to the exertion of private and public power. Cotton's history is full of such state initiatives—ranging from tariff regimes to colonialism. Commodity histories empirically investigate how states constituted and structured the "global."

This emphasis on power, moreover, allows historians who write about a particular commodity to consider the many different social groups, not just economic and political elites, who shaped global interactions. As the distribution of social power in particular locales mattered a great deal in structuring local, national, and global markets, we can understand how people without access to capital or state power nonetheless played a role in shaping global connections. In fact, commodity-focused histories allow us to see how the shape of capitalism and thus the modern world were very much related to social conflict—and that this social conflict was often global in nature. One of the more problematic effects of some world history has been its willingness to ignore the lessons of the social history revolution, but focusing on a commodity allows—in fact, requires—us to bring a good dose of social history back into global history.

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The history of cotton can illuminate some of these general points. For most people in today's United States or Europe, cotton seems very distant. Few of us know or can imagine that for about nine hundred years, from the year 1000 to 1900, the growing, spinning, and weaving of cotton was the most important human manufacturing activity. In

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many areas of the world, from Central America to East Africa, from Anatolia to China, a great many people spent their days growing, spinning, and weaving cotton. Indeed, it was cotton's central importance in the pre–Industrial-Revolution world that spurred the innovations that lead to drastic improvements in its production techniques. The cotton industry was at the center of the Industrial Revolution, and wherever mechanized factory production emerged, it was always applied first to the production of cotton. During the nineteenth century, there was no industry that employed more people—and of course, cotton dominated a huge swath of the North Atlantic region—from the slave plantations of the U.S. South to the industrial cities of England. In the course of the nineteenth century, cotton manufacturing spread throughout Europe, to Brazil, Japan, Mexico, and Egypt, among other places. The advent of mechanized cotton production in many ways was the very symbol of a country's entry into modernity.

In Britain early in the nineteenth century, cotton became the most important manufacturing industry, raw cotton the most important import, and cloth and yarn Britain's most important export product. In India, shifts within its huge cotton industry away from spinning and toward the growing of cotton for export caused tectonic upheavals in its economy. In continental Europe, cotton manufacturing became the first manufacturing industry. In the United States, raw cotton exports established the young nation's place in the global economy. In Mexico, Egypt, India, and Brazil, the first tentative steps toward industrialization were taken, all of them in cotton. Egyptian agriculture was turned upside down to facilitate cotton production for export, and by the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, peasants throughout Africa, in northern Argentina, in Australia, and elsewhere turned their soil into cotton fields. Huge profits were accumulated in cottons—the Barings, the Rothschilds, the Wards, the Browns, the Rathbones, the Tatas, the Birlas, and other well-known merchant and manufacturing families all profited from cotton. Throughout the world, ever more people began to use ever more cotton textiles, a change especially notable in areas that came late to cotton, such as Europe, revolutionizing how people dressed and kept clean. For the nineteenth century as a whole, cotton was as central and important as oil would be in the twentieth.

And cotton is still important today. Last year, about 120 million cotton bales were produced throughout the world, every one of them weighing between 400 and 500 pounds—enough cotton to produce 20 t-shirts for every inhabitant on our planet. Piled on top of one another these bales would make a tower 40,000 miles high. Globally, up to 350

million people work in today's cotton industry, a number never before reached in history and one that represents between 3 and 4 percent of the entire human population. Huge cotton plantations can be found around the world, from China to India to the United States, from West Africa to Central Asia. Tightly pressed raw fibers are still shipped to factories around the world, where hundreds of thousands of workers spin, weave, and eventually turn them into clothing. The finished products are sold everywhere, from remote country stores to multinational supermarkets such as Wal-Mart and Carrefour. Indeed, cotton goods are among the very few products that can be acquired virtually anywhere, and thus cotton's history demonstrates the impressive and unprecedented increase in human productivity and human consumption that industrialization in particular and capitalism more generally have enabled. As a recent U.S. advertising campaign put it, quite accurately: "Cotton—the fabric of our lives."

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A commodity history of cotton thus captures an industry that was important through many centuries, played a key role in some of the most significant processes of world history—from the Industrial Revolution to the great divergence to the expansion of slavery—and also one that unfolded on and connected all the continents. But what matters the most is that cotton was so central to the long history of capitalism.

The history of capitalism is obviously important to historians, and it is also an issue of great contemporary relevance. Few topics have animated the chattering classes more than capitalism. In the wake of the global economic crisis of 2008, questions about the nature, past, and viability of capitalism suddenly appeared on evening talk shows and in newspapers throughout the world. The discussion crossed political boundaries, with conservative newspapers in Germany and the United Kingdom running stories on the "future of capitalism" (as if in doubt that there was such a thing), while Korean Marxists among others hammered away at an analysis of capitalism's allegedly self-destructive tendencies. The discussion continues with unabated intensity, crossing all political, ideological, and professional divides. Pope Francis has made capitalism a central theme of his papacy, and French economist Thomas Picketty attained rock star status by publishing a 700-page book chock full of tables and statistics, with the succinct but decisively unsexy title *Capital in the Twenty-First Century*.

This vibrant debate should be welcomed: If we want to understand our contemporary world, we need to come to terms with capitalism.

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But our thinking about capitalism urgently needs the voices of historians. Capitalism has a very long history—the social and geographic expansion of capitalism is by now half a millennium in the making. Capitalism's ability to revolutionize societies, technologies, states, and many aspects of our lives poses a great number of questions that can be answered only from a long historical perspective. In such an analysis, historians have a number of advantages over economists, some of whom have an unfortunate tendency to naturalize certain economic arrangements and to search for the laws that explain them, often with allegedly mathematical precision.

A commodity-focused history, in contrast, can trace both the historical specificity of capitalism and how it changed over time. A commodity history does not so much analyze the abstract "nature" of capitalism, but instead tries through a detailed empirical analysis to understand its actual functioning, what I call "capitalism in action." And that "capitalism in action" worked quite differently from the capitalism often encountered in economics textbooks.

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If we look at capitalism through a commodity focus, one of the first things we see is that capitalism can be properly understood only as a global system, an insight that should not be controversial, but that breaks with much previous historiography. We cannot understand the history of capitalism or cotton if we tell it from the perspective of just one place, one region, or one country. We have hundreds of books on the history of cotton plantations in the Americas, spinning mills in Lancashire, and weavers in India, among others. It would be impossible to write a global commodity study without these works, but it is a commodity study that illuminates new links among them. By focusing on connections among developments in distant parts of the world, we connect the histories of such diverse groups of people as central Asian peasants and Indian weavers, merchants in Liverpool and enslaved workers in the American South, demanding consumers in West Africa and Chinese cotton industrialists—groups you usually do not find in the same book or even the same section of the library. The history of capitalism as seen through the history of a commodity thus becomes a connected history, and brings in a set of actors beyond the usual Florentine bankers, English industrialists, and assembly-line workers in Ford's River Rouge factory.

The history of cotton, in fact, allows us to see with unusual clarity that the history of capitalism is in important ways about the connections

forged between different places, different regimes of labor, and different kinds of states–free trade and imperialism, violence and contract. These global connections have shifted constantly, as have the roles of particular places and groups of people. Indeed, one of the secrets of capitalism's forward march is its seemingly unending ability to recast the geography of capital, labor, and state power.

A commodity-centered study also allows us to delve deeper into very local circumstances, thus showing the importance of the local to the constitution of the global. A great problem of world or global history can be that it describes the world as a network of globally connected actors (such as merchants), in which local interests and local or even national distributions of power are inconsequential. But the global cannot be understood without the local, and the opposite is equally true. The local conditions the global, and the global constrains the options available to local actors. In fact, the local and the global cannot be separated from one another, since social processes unfold on a range of different but always connected spatial scales.

There is one more important contribution that a commodity-centered world history can make to our understanding of capitalism, and that is the role of the state. States played an exceedingly important role in the development of cotton and capitalism. It has become fashionable to see state intervention as somehow contradictory to the unfolding of capitalism—the more state, the less capitalism, and vice versa. Looked at from a long historical perspective, however, just the opposite is the case: States have played an enormously important role in the development of capitalism, especially of industrial capitalism. States have protected industries from unwanted imports—for example the textile industry in the United States. States have created legal systems, helped mobilize workers, conquered distant markets, created infrastructures, and supported industries in many different ways. Take Britain, for example, a powerful state in the eighteenth century, and the pioneer in mechanized cotton production. Because Britain was in a nearly continuous state of war, high levels of taxation, to name just one form of governmental intervention, were necessary. Moreover, Britain governed a huge empire, created barriers to the import of Indian cotton textiles, and forbade the export of new-fangled cotton manufacturing machines and the emigration of its skilled workers. Using Britain as an example, one could show that capitalism is the result of the power of the owners of capital and of states, the one enabling the rise of the other.

Last but not least, one of the most fundamental insights we gain from a commodity history is that when we think about capitalism, we

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should look not only at industry and cities, but also—especially—at the countryside and agriculture. The countryside was an enormously important source of raw materials, labor, and markets, and a very large part of the history of capitalism looks at how capital owners and powerful states tried to revolutionize the countryside and integrate it into the global capitalist economy. The transformation of the global countryside is indeed a core theme in global history.

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Thinking about the importance of the countryside and agriculture to the history of global capitalism raises the question of slavery, a core issue for global historians.

As with all historical research, a good starting point is what others have said about the problems we are concerned with. Too often, the question of how slavery and capitalism are related is presented as almost a new avenue of research, but this is clearly not the case. Indeed, just the opposite is true: The question of how slavery relates to modern economic development has been debated for at least two hundred years. Abolitionists, for example, harped persistently on the connection between North Atlantic wealth and the institution of slavery. Pro-slavery advocates were equally convinced that slavery was one of the foundations of modern economic development, an idea most famously demonstrated by James Hammond's comment that "cotton is king." And Europeans—ranging from the editors of the *Economist* to Karl Marx—saw clearly the central role of slavery in the industrial development of Europe. Just to cite one example: In September of 1861, at the beginning of the American Civil War, the *Economist* called the action of Union general John C. Frémont, who was emancipating enslaved workers in Missouri, a "fearful measure" and warned that it might spread to other slaveholding states, "inflict[ing] utter ruin and universal desolation on those fertile territories" and on the merchants of Boston and New York, "whose prosperity . . . has always been derived" to a large extent from those territories. While Karl Marx's observations on the importance of what he called "primitive accumulation" were theoretically more rigorous, the substance of his observations was indistinguishable from wide swaths of nineteenth-century public opinion.

Yet what had seemed so obvious for so long a time had, by the last decades of the nineteenth century, entered a long period of mystification. Once slavery was abolished in the Americas, its former role in enabling North Atlantic economic growth was actively forgotten. In fact, elites in the North Atlantic started to tell new stories about themselves, stories

in which slavery did not have much place. As North Atlantic societies became much wealthier than much of the rest of the world, their elites emphasized their technical inventiveness, their superior institutions, their allegedly more rational religious beliefs, and their superior "civilizational" state as explanations for what later historians would call the "great divergence." Slavery did not have much of a place in this account, nor did other forms of violence, coercion, and expropriation.

While this account resonated with the utopian intellectual traditions of liberal capitalism, it ignored capitalism's actual history, almost as if that actual history was too embarrassing to be mentioned. The erasure of slavery from the history of capitalism became even more pronounced after the Russian Revolution and especially during the Cold War, when for many it became a matter of urgency to connect the rise of capitalism with the spread of freedom. Modernization theory in particular postulated a trajectory for the history of capitalist societies that was quite definitely about the spread of freedom and democracy, and the institution of slavery did not sit comfortably within that narrative.

This did not mean that the history of slavery was completely ignored. Those European societies that had been deeply implicated in slavery, but had kept the institution at a geographic distance—such as France and the United Kingdom—remembered it principally for their role in its abolition. The Dutch preferred to tell a story of their golden age that left out any mention of slavery. And the Germans, Swiss, Danes, and Norwegians conveniently repressed any mentioning to slavery whatsoever, despite, as recent historical scholarship has shown, their manifold connections to Atlantic slavery. But this strategy of forgetting was all but impossible in the United States, where slavery had thrived on its own national territory. Consequently, in the United States there was an outpouring of scholarship on slavery, even during the Cold War years. In the wake of the Civil Rights movement, the history of slavery as the nation's ultimate moral failure also entered high school curricula and the general culture.

As much as knowledge about the history of slavery spread in the United States, however, it became quarantined as a regional issue. Slavery was a problem of the American South, and it was thanks to the North's heroic antislavery politics that slavery was eventually overcome in a violent civil war. Acknowledging slavery in this way did not threaten the more general modernization narrative, and, arguably, it amplified capitalism's story of its emancipatory trajectory. Slavery for much of the United States, and for many Americans, was "over there" just as it was "over there" for the British and the French. Slavery was a

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remnant of an earlier, premodern moment, a violent system done away with by nothing less than capitalist revolution.

Of course, discourses on the importance of slavery to the development of capitalism never entirely disappeared. But now they did not emanate from the pages of the *Economist* or the nation's economic elite, nor from textbooks in American schools, but rather from the margins of the history profession, from people like W. E. B. DuBois, Philip Foner, C. L. R. James, Abdullah Ly, Raoul Prebisch, Walter Rodney, Eric Williams, and others. While their works did not structure mainstream interpretations of slavery, and rarely found their way into popular culture or school curricula, they assembled important evidence for the relationship between slavery and capitalism, and kept the question alive and furthered analyses of it.

Thanks to the research and stamina of this large group of often-marginalized scholars, we now know a lot about slavery's capitalism. But we are also continuously learning more, as a new generation of scholars has begun to grapple with this question again.

This more extensive empirical knowledge, however, has also raised some big questions about slavery and capitalism that are still in need of answers.

The arguments on slavery and capitalism can be broadly grouped into two strands: There are authors who trace the importance of slavery to the economic development of a particular nation state. In recent years the most significant such project was Nick Draper and Catherine Hall's work on the legacy of slave owning on the British economy. But there are other such projects that look at France, Switzerland, and Central Europe. And of course there is much work of this kind on the United States.

There are also those historians who try to understand the importance of slavery as part of the global history of capitalism, among them Kenneth Pomeranz and Joseph Inikori. The evidence they have assembled seriously undermines many of the stories that we have been telling about capitalism. It shows that the popular narrative connecting capitalism to the spread of human freedom might be, well, incomplete. It seems as if violence, coercion, and enslavement were not just incidental to the spread of capitalism, but critical to it.

These stories also challenge important tenants of Marxism, particularly its postulation that wage labor is the labor of capitalism. A focus on slavery shows that the labor of capitalism can take many different forms, indeed that capitalism is fundamentally characterized and strengthened by that very diversity of labor regimes.

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These are all important insights, but we make things too simple if we leave them there. Yes, the act of recovery is important and has significant implications for contemporary discussions of domestic and global inequality. Yet what we know raises fundamental questions that the debate has not yet fully engaged or answered.

Most important among them is this question: What precisely was it about slavery that gave it a role in the history of capitalism? A second question arises from that one—namely, why did slavery eventually lose its central role? If slavery was so spectacularly profitable and as essential to the unfolding of capitalism as some authors now enthusiastically assert, how do we comprehend the actual history of emancipation?

First, why was slavery so important to a particular moment in the history of capitalism?

This is an issue that is directly related to the question of the transformation of the global countryside. Ironically, the importance of slavery was rooted as much in the relative weakness of European capitalists as in their strength. To be sure, capturing huge territories thousands of miles away from their home countries, shipping millions of workers to these territories, and then forcing them to grow agricultural commodities and dig minerals were awe-inspiring signs of power. Yet it was also a sign that they had failed to mobilize land, labor, and commodities in other ways; indeed, it was a sign that the market they celebrated in the abstract did not yet work in the ways they envisioned. The capitalist transformation they aspired to was in fact a huge and difficult project that met resistance from both elites and commoners.

The biggest problem faced by those looking to expand capitalism was how to dominate production. Whether in Europe, India, China, or elsewhere, artisans and peasant producers had myriad ways to resist their subordination to commercial capital. In much of the world, for example, rural cultivators enjoyed significant rights to the land and to the products of their labor. And often these people were embedded in political structures, such as those in the Ottoman Empire, that constrained or even precluded the revolutionizing agenda of commercial capitalists. Yet the expansion of commercial capital rested on the transformation of the countryside, and this project succeeded first and foremost in the Americas—through the embrace of the institution of slavery. It was there, for the first time, that commercial capitalists came to dominate production and control labor on a truly massive scale. And in the process they were able to overcome some of the resource constraints of the European continent.

The history of cotton underscores these points well: With the expansion of cotton manufacturing in eighteenth-century Europe,

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almost all cotton used in European factories was grown by enslaved workers—first in the West Indies and Brazil, then in the southern parts of the United States. Efforts to secure cotton from peasant producers in India, West Africa, or the Ottoman Empire usually failed, despite the work of British and French colonial administrators and cotton merchants. They failed not because European manufacturers preferred slave-grown cotton as such, but because merchants could not secure sufficient quantities at prices competitive with slave-grown cotton.

Situating slavery within the larger—and global—processes of transforming the countryside thus allows us to see much more clearly why slavery came to play such a crucial role at this particular moment in the history of capitalism. The nature of slavery's capitalism can indeed be fully understood only from such a global perspective.

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There is still the question of why slavery did not remain a central part of the mobilization of labor under capitalism, or, for that matter, why it did not spread to Europe. In some ways that is puzzling: It was widely recognized that slavery had been an efficient system for the mobilization of labor and had made possible the domination of labor that had evaded earlier capitalists. With the transition to industrial capitalism, huge new labor needs arose, and slavery seemed like it might possibly answer them.

But that is not what happened, and therefore we need to be somewhat wary of some of the more enthusiastic arguments that have been forwarded about slavery as the "essence" of capitalism. Slavery, after all, was also an unstable system of production, and the enormous violence done to enslaved workers testified to the constant threat they posed to the interests of their owners. British cotton manufacturers, among others, worried constantly about their dependence on such a potentially unstable system of production. The eventual collapse of slavery had a lot to do with these struggles.

An important additional factor was that slavery was not just a system of labor exploitation, but a system of rule that drew on state power. Wherever they resided, slave owners accumulated tremendous political power—indeed, their domination of labor rested quite directly on that political power. They needed that power to protect the institution of slavery, expand its reach into ever more lands, improve infrastructures, and position their economies within the global economy as an exporter of agricultural commodities. They had a particular vision for the political economy, and that vision increasingly collided with the political economy envisioned by manufacturing capitalists. Able to

mobilize labor through wage payments, these manufacturers demanded a strong state that would raise tariffs, build infrastructures conducive to domestic industrialization, and, in the case of the United States, guarantee the territorial extension of free labor. These two political economies were irreconcilable, and no part of the world shows that better than the United States, where it turned out to be impossible for them to inhabit the same political space.

And then slavery declined for another reason: New ways of mobilizing and disciplining labor had been found, and new ways to revolutionize the global countryside discovered. States and capitalists had gained such enormous strength from the wages of the slave-based global economy that they could push infrastructures into the global countryside, introduce new legal frameworks for commodity production, impose European capital and power (in the form, for example, of taxation), and limit peasants' legal rights to common resources. In effect, peasants could be made to engage in commodity production through the mechanisms of the market. Slavery had thus created the conditions for its own overcoming.

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We cannot know if slavery was the only possible way into the modern industrial world, but we do know that it was the path that was taken. We will never know if Europe and North America could have grown rich without slavery, but we do know that industrial capitalism and the great divergence in fact emerged also from the violent cauldron of slavery, colonialism, and the expropriation of land from native peoples.

When we marshal lofty arguments about the West's superior economic performance and build these arguments upon an account of the West's allegedly superior institutions—such as private-property rights, lean states, and the rule of law—we need to remember that the world forged by Westerners was also characterized by vast confiscations of land and labor, huge state intervention in the form of colonialism, and rule by violence and coercion. And we also need to qualify the fairy tale we like to tell about capitalism and free labor. Global capitalism is characterized by a whole variety of labor regimes, one of which was slavery.

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A commodity-centered history can help us understand important issues in global history, such as, for example, the history of capitalism and slavery's place within it. What such a perspective also does, in the process, is to sustain audiences for world history.

I remember a few years ago, when world or global history became fashionable for the first time, we had agonizing discussions about the "audience" for such research. It was argued that national history had a natural audience: people who identified with a particular nation-state and thus had an interest in how it came into being and evolved over time. But who would read global histories in the absence of global identities or global political units?

It seems to me that these worries were overstated. World and global histories have potentially very large audiences, particularly when they deal with problems perceived to be urgent and global in scope—environmental, cultural, or economic concerns. A commodity focused approach to global history is one way of attracting such audiences, by taking something familiar to many readers and using that familiarity to discuss serious and large-scale issues.

And that makes me hopeful. The project that we are engaging in has something far-reaching, even utopian to it. In a world in which history as a discipline arose hand in hand with the nation-state and played a large role in its constitution, in a world in which almost all historical research is institutionalized along national lines, there is something profound in emphasizing that there is just one history, that the subject of what we do is human history as a whole. If ever we see the emergence of some form of global civil society, global history, will, I am sure, play a role in its constitution.